

SIDDHARTH HALBE/NETFLIX

**SCREEN PRESENCE**
**Madhuri Dixit-Nene in *The Fame Game***

In **THE FAME GAME**, writer Sri Rao delves into the pressures of stardom and critiques how the film industry deals with actresses

## LEISURE

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# THE FLIP SIDE OF FAME

**Madhuri Dixit-Nene's character in an upcoming Netflix series explores the fraught life of a superstar actress**

I have nothing left to prove," says Madhuri Dixit-Nene. No, she isn't hanging up her boots; she's simply reminding one of what she has achieved in the nearly three decades spent in front of the camera. A film which ran in cinemas for over 100 weeks (*Hum Aapke Hai Koun..!*); multiple dances that have inspired generations of women, and even men; and films where she superseded her male co-stars. So when Netflix approached US-based writer Sri Rao to develop a series about the fraught life of a superstar heroine, she was the only actress he had in mind. "One of my primary objectives was to create a vehicle for Madhuri in the way that Julia Roberts, Nicole Kidman, Reese Witherspoon have got on TV in the US," says Rao. "She is the greatest living actress in India today and deserves a story and role of that calibre."

Playing a superstar, Anamika Anand, in *The Fame Game* came easy to Madhuri. It also gave her the opportunity to "be with the times", something her two teenage sons like her to be. "I understood where she (Anamika) comes from, what she feels, her insecurities, what she pines for, and what she is missing out in life," says Madhuri. "I have sometimes gone through what she has." Watching the first four episodes of the eight-part series, there's a lot that Anamika has to contend with. The woman of the house, she has an insecure producer-husband, two kids with teenage issues, an overbearing mother, an obsessive fan, a co-star who isn't over her and a career that the world thinks is on its last legs.

Rao uses the premise of an actress who goes missing to look at the pressures of stardom and subtly critique the film industry, which is perhaps eager to write actresses off much sooner than actors. Today, Madhuri isn't headlining big-budget films like some of her male co-stars from the 1990s still do, but, at 54, she continues to be busy—be it judging dance shows or playing the lead part in a Netflix series. Is there a formula for a long career, we ask. "You have to work really hard, be sincere, make sure you do everything to the best of your abilities and try to think out of the box even if people advise you not to," says Madhuri. ■

**–Suhani Singh**